



DONATE

ACCOUNT

DONATE



The Salt Lake Tribune

Christian Sears: Don't blame 'the Russians' for Putin's aggression

Not everyone in that nation supports the attack on Ukraine.



Christian Sears

By Christian Sears | Special to The Tribune | Feb. 24, 2022, 8:00 a.m. | Updated: 11:53 a.m.

Add as Preferred Source

Comment

Tanks rolling over the Ukrainian border, ready to bulldoze any resistance. Olympic athletes testing positive for banned substances. Poison in the bloodstream of Putin's political opponents. Digital fingerprints on attacks

against the very bedrock of our republic. It's no wonder that, for many Americans, the mental image of "the Russians" consists of Soviet stormtroopers, marching with flawless unison in a military parade across Red Square.

"The Russians" conjures up those images for me, too. But it also describes good friends, who virtually attended my wedding. It describes former students, like the little boy who kept picking his nose while I tried to explain the English language's past simple tense. It brings to mind tables overflowing with delicious kebabs and hearty soups, at luncheons meant to welcome me as a guest. It brings to mind the Russian dads I met, who were always eager to show me whatever project they were working on in their garage or backyard. And it reminds me of the mothers I met, who are now worried about how they will afford groceries, as sanctions hit and their economy begins to falter.

It's a simple distinction—but one that's crucial, and all too easy to forget—the Russian people are not their president.



Vladimir Putin is an evil man, as evidenced by his choice to invade Ukraine. Unfortunately, the Russian military is perfectly willing to shed innocent blood at his command. The Russian media will portray this invasion as the sensible, even moral, thing to do. And to Putin's delight, many Russians view him as a 21st century tsar, with all the earthly and divine authority that entails.

But [many in Russia](#), probably more than those who support invasion, will regard Putin with even greater contempt, distrust and fear as war breaks out in Ukraine. (Calling it "the Ukraine" is a subtle way to reinforce its status as the Russian borderlands, thereby supporting Putin's imperialism, by the way.) They will pray for the safety of their neighbors in Ukraine, many of whom have relatives in Russia. They will be disgusted by their own country's actions, as we have often been disgusted with ours.

Yet our state officials and media alike will almost certainly attribute the outbreak of violence in Eastern Europe to "the Russians." I fear we will equate their president and his soldiers with the Russian people — including those who have immigrated to our country. I fear we will forgive ourselves for letting Trump lock children in cages on our border, while we blame all Russians equally for the violence on their border. I fear we will forget that, in some nations, it is illegal, even fatal, to criticize the president.

I hope I'm wrong. I hope I'm wrong about all of it. But in case I'm not, I suggest we all try to remember the shared humanity that binds us to those living on the other side of Putin's carnivorous border. I believe we cannot find our way back to peace unless we remember that bond.

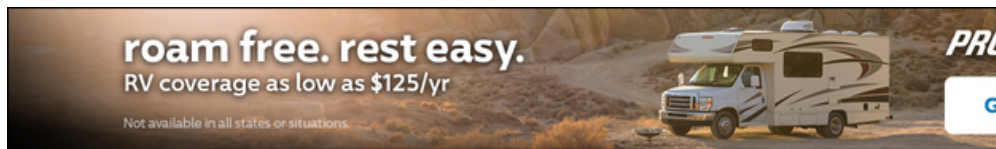


Get Inside Voices newsletter. A weekly collection of ideas, perspectives and solutions from across Utah.

This site is protected by reCAPTCHA and the Google Privacy Policy and Terms of Service apply.

While Russia, as a nation, has earned its ugly reputation, not all of its people are cold, cruel, and callous. The Russians I've met are quite the opposite: kind, generous, curious, and humorous. Find out for yourself. Try visiting the nearest "European grocery store," or going to a restaurant that serves shchi, plov, or shaverma.

If that's not an option for you, then take my word for it. I'm married to a Russian. She bears no resemblance to her country's autocrat.



Christian Sears, Medford, Mass., was born and raised in Sugar House and is a graduate of the University of Utah. He taught English in Vladimir, Russia, from 2018 to 2019.

Support free news for Utah

sltrib.com is now free to access — no subscription required. We made this decision because we believe access to trustworthy, independent news shouldn't depend on what you can afford — especially as misinformation and AI-generated content continue to rise.

Free to read doesn't mean free to produce. Our reporters show up every day to ask hard questions and hold powerful institutions to account. That work takes resources. As a nonprofit newsroom, we rely on support from people who believe it matters. Make a donation today to fund local news that serves Utah communities.

You can help us bring more local news to more communities today.